the Maldives, and the Indian Ocean region. But the development that ushered in this era was the 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War.

The Bangladesh crisis arose in part from structural realities: while the political and economic power in Pakistan lay in the West (especially the provinces of Punjab and Sindh), over half of the country's population was composed of ethnic Bengalis in the geographically detached East Pakistan. Student protests and growing resentment in East Pakistan following the 1965 India–Pakistan War led to calls for greater autonomy. In 1966, Sheikh Mujibur Rehman of the Awami League outlined specific demands for autonomy that included considerable independence on fiscal, administrative, and defence matters, including a separate currency for East Pakistan. He was accused of conspiring with India, tried, and jailed in 1968. The next year, Pakistan's military leader General Yahya Khan suspended the Constitution and declared martial law in Pakistan, to be followed by elections in 1970. To Yahya's surprise, Mujib's Awami League scored an overwhelming electoral victory in East Pakistan, winning 160 out of 162 seats, and thus giving it a majority. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party (PPP) finished a distant second with eighty-one seats. This undesirable outcome from Yahya's point of view resulted in an increasingly brutal military crackdown in February and March 1971. Pakistan banned the Awami League and branded Mujib and his supporters 'enemies of Pakistan'. [6]

India was initially wary about intervening in this situation, despite requests for asylum and other forms of support from Awami League members in March 1971. Violating Pakistani sovereignty could have had blowback effects, the Pakistani military was well-equipped, and there were concerns about Chinese intervention and a two-front war. In April, K. Subrahmanyam—a civil servant who was then heading the Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses think tank in New Delhi—sent a memo to the defence minister and other senior officials. After laying out the options and counter-arguments, he made the case for a 'decisive intervention and withdrawal', and concluded that, 'It is obvious the benefits far outweigh the costs of intervention.' [7] But even as over six million refugees entered India